building district offices. ‘We already have offices of our own in ten districts [Ballari, Mysuru, Mangalore, Udupi, Chamarajanagar, Mandya, Hubli, Davanagere and Shivamogga],’ he answered. ‘In eighteen other districts, we have purchased the land already.’[64]

The southern Karnataka district of Mandya reflects the speed at which the party moved. When Sandeep Moudgal visited it in May 2018 for the Karnataka assembly elections, the BJP did not own an office there. ‘They had a small place and were operating out of there,’ he said. In his recollection, during the 2019 Lok Sabha elections, B.L. Santosh, the BJP’s national organisation secretary, visited Mandya and told the local party officers, ‘whatever you guys need you will get. If you need space or if you need money, both will come.’ The local unit then, as a first step, took a place on lease at ₹1,80,000 a year and set up a party office there. ‘Now they have an office in Mandya,’ he pointed out to me in February 2020. ‘It was sanctioned within ten days by the BJP leadership.[65]

The BJP has been focused on building district party offices because it sees them as the skeletal structure holding together the party organisation. As Ravi Kumar explained, party offices are important because they act as organisational focal points for joint activity. ‘Everyone will come to our office,’ he said. ‘State president and general secretary are active within the party. They are meant to call for programmes each month. They have to do it as part of their jobs. In each programme, there is a call centre at the mandal level and at the district level to call people. If a big event happens, for example, Delhi election results will come tomorrow, if our party gets a majority, then, in all 300 mandals, small gatherings will be held to observe Vijay Utsav. There is an email to everybody that will be sent and the district office will be key.’[66]

This is a sentiment I also heard from party workers up north in Mathura, where the BJP built a new district office in 2018. The building was closed because of the national lockdown when I visited in July 2020, but it had replaced the BJP’s old office in the city, which had been rented from the nagar palika. ‘It is totally hi-tech,’ explained a local party official. ‘You don’t need to go out for anything else. It has a different office for the zila president, different for the mahanagar president, a very big badhiya hall for meetings, internet,